"THEY WILL PROBABLY BE MAKING A BIG BLAST OUT OF THAT in the next day or two," said Dean Rusk to the president and his aides during the afternoon session of ExCom, which began at 4:00 p.m. that day. No longer concerned about the possible outbreak of hostilities and nuclear war—the reaction that the news had provoked from McNamara as soon as he heard it—Rusk proposed issuing a public statement suggesting that the plane was on a routine mission and had got lost because of instrument failure. Kennedy was against any announcement whatever. "I think we are better off not to do it if we can get away with not having some leak," said the president. "Because I think our problem is to maintain our credibility with Khrushchev."

Kennedy was thinking about future negotiations with Khrushchev over the missile swap. He was prepared to negotiate the deal, but on one condition: Khrushchev had to stop the deployment of missiles already on Cuban soil. "I think we ought to be able to say that the matter of Turkey and so on, in fact all these matters, can be discussed if he'll cease work," said Kennedy to his advisers. "Otherwise, he's going to announce that we've rejected his proposal. And then, where are we?" He still was in the minority but kept pushing, and when he left the room for a moment, Robert Kennedy, who sensed the new determination in his brother's attitude, told the gathering: "I think that he almost said that he would be willing to discuss Turkish bases or anything that they want to discuss." By "they" Robert meant the Soviets in general and Khrushchev in particular.

Most of the ExCom members continued to oppose the removal of the missiles from Turkey, suggesting that Kennedy propose to Khrushchev that they negotiate that issue once the Cuban crisis was resolved. "Well, isn't that really rejecting their proposal of this morning?" asked Kennedy. He wanted ExCom to discuss political and diplomatic means of removing the missiles from Turkey, not debate the idea itself. "We have the question of a choice between the bilateral arrangements with Turkey—in which we more or less do it. Or whether we go through NATO and let NATO put the pressure on, and also explain to the Turks what's going to happen to them if it doesn't—if they end up slowing things down." The opposition, represented by Bundy and Dillon, had shifted gears, questioning whether